



WEDDING PLANNERS

DELHI



Roses from Thailand, turbans from Jodhpur, chocolates from Paris. The marriage market has gone upmarket.

■ By Deepika Khatri

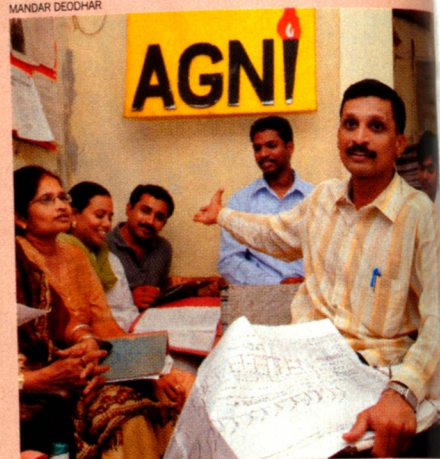
The bride descends a long flight of stairs in a flowing Rohit Bal lehenga choli, shimmering in a long veil with appliqué and gota work. A shower of rose petals, flown in from Thailand, falls on her. The groom is wearing a special three-coloured turban wound by a specialist in Jodhpur, the *mithai* is from Kolkata; and the chocolates, at Rs 3,250 a box, have been handmade in Paris. It's just another day in the life of 45-year-old wedding planner Vandana Mohan's life, but a big fat ceremony for her clients.

Four hours ago, the same scene looked like a chaotic war zone as florists worked with 400 kg of lilies, carnations and roses. Silk, georgette and lace linen fluttering gracefully over couches, were strewn on the

floor. Now with candles lit and diyas shimmering, the stage is set for a fairytale to come true, albeit at a stiff price, varying from Rs 5 lakh to Rs 50 lakh.

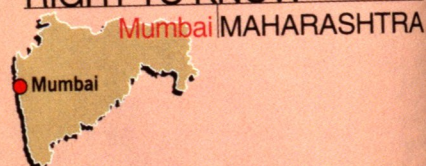
The culmination of the big fat Indian wedding, a Rs 2,000-crore industry in Delhi alone, is a celebration befitting a maharaja. Guests in diamond-studded finery raise their glasses of champagne in a toast to the newly weds. It's another of Mohan's successes and she's soon back to work on another. The hum of activity in Mohan's M.F. Husain-adorned office is palpable as the deadline for the second wedding approaches. Venues can vary from a beach setting in Goa to a palace in Udaipur, and winning the client's trust is the toughest part of the job. Intricate details are worked out and wedding gifts are a whole new ballgame, with a specially inscribed Moët and Chandon champagne bottles being flown in from France at Rs 5,200-a piece.

Such ostentation may be why Mohan and her husband, who is in the real estate business, have other plans for their 14-year-old daughter Vedika's wedding. A simple, no-frills affair in a temple and a marriage that lasts.



ONE MAN ARMY: James John

RIGHT TO KNOW



Fire Starter

A group of alert citizens use the Right to Information Act to change their little world

■ By Kimi Dangor

"To change the system, you must penetrate it," says 23-year-old Muringathery Sebastian Varghese, seated in a tiny tenement in Bhamanpuri village in Mumbai. As youth president of his church, this mechanical engineering student has discovered a weapon that will help him understand and navigate this system better. "The Right to Information Act is like a *brahmastra*," chimes Pramod Sawant, 25, an employee with a media group. It's a national holiday, August 15, but the two young men have dutifully turned up for the Action for Good Governance for Networking in India (AGNI) and Active Alert Citizen's Forum meeting. Seated around a small room lined with yellowed newspaper clippings are also social activists James John, Ravi Nair, Ashok Pai,